

THE UNIVERSAL HOUSE OF JUSTICE

25 October 2016

To selected National Spiritual Assemblies

Dear Bahá'í Friends,

With profound sorrow, the Universal House of Justice has instructed us to share with you information pertaining to the martyrdom of Farhang Amírí from Yazd, Iran, on 26 September 2016, and to request you to take action, as outlined below.

The circumstances surrounding Mr. Amírí's murder are now well established. On the evening of 25 September, two young men arrived outside his home and, since he was not there, spoke with one of his sons, asking to purchase Mr. Amírí's van. Mr. Amírí's son said that he was not aware that his father wished to sell the vehicle, but the two men insisted. He asked for their contact information, but they made excuses and left. The following evening, the same two individuals returned and met with Mr. Amírí himself outside his residence while family members remained inside. Soon after, Mr. Amírí was heard screaming. A family member, who was then joined by several other people, found him severely injured with multiple stab wounds in the chest. At the same time, local shopkeepers apprehended a man who was running away from the scene and delivered him to the police; a second man was also detained by the police later. Mr. Amírí was brought by ambulance to the hospital where he died a few minutes after arrival.

While being questioned by the police in front of witnesses, the two suspects admitted killing Mr. Amírí with a knife they brought with them for this purpose. When asked about their motive, one of the suspects answered that he carried out the murder because he knew Mr. Amírí was a Bahá'í. Even though during subsequent interrogations the two suspects claimed that they had attacked him because the discussion over the sale of the vehicle escalated, the most recent reports confirm that the suspects have admitted that their actions were indeed religiously motivated.

Such a heinous deed is a consequence of a longstanding, systematic effort by the authorities to encourage hatred and bigotry. Just in the city of Yazd alone, there have been multiple acts of persecution over the past few years, including dozens of wrongful arrests and imprisonments as well as scores of raids on Bahá'í residences and businesses. Mr. Amírí's own children had their business and residences searched last year by government agents who confiscated laptops, telephones, and other items. In early August of this year, a believer in this town was told while being interrogated by government agents in Yazd that they knew of people in the city who intended on killing Bahá'ís....

With loving Bahá'í greetings,

Department of the Secretariat

[signed: The Universal House of Justice]